

ENT Service Line Handbook

Meridian Health Partners
Department of Otolaryngology (ENT)
Service Line Handbook - Version 3.1
Effective Date: 2024-03-15

1. Department Mission and Scope

1.1. The Meridian Health Partners Department of Otolaryngology provides comprehensive outpatient medical evaluation and management for conditions affecting the ear, nose, and throat in adult and pediatric patients aged 2 years and above.

1.2. This handbook outlines the operational parameters, patient care guidelines, and administrative policies specific to ENT services across all Meridian Health Partners sites.

2. Conditions Accepted for Outpatient Management

2.1. The Department accepts referrals for the following conditions, subject to pre-authorization requirements where applicable:

2.1.1. Chronic rhinosinusitis (medical management only).

2.1.2. Allergic rhinitis and related conditions.

2.1.3. Recurrent tonsillitis or pharyngitis (non-acute).

2.1.4. Chronic otitis externa or media (non-acute).

2.1.5. Conductive and sensorineural hearing loss (requiring pre-referral audiometry within 6 months).

2.1.6. Tinnitus.

2.1.7. Non-emergent vertigo and dizziness.

2.1.8. Nasal polyps (medical management only).

2.1.9. Non-emergent voice changes, dysphonia, and laryngeal irritation.

2.1.10. Initial evaluation for obstructive sleep apnea (OSA), prior to surgical consideration by a dedicated sleep surgeon.

3. Conditions Explicitly Not Accepted for Initial Outpatient Management

3.1. The Department will not accept direct outpatient referrals for conditions requiring immediate emergency intervention or specialized tertiary care. These cases must be routed via emergency services or specialized departments as indicated:

3.1.1. Acute epiglottitis.

3.1.2. Facial trauma including fractures or deep lacerations.

3.1.3. Suspected foreign body aspiration into the trachea or bronchi.

3.1.4. Acute, sudden sensorineural hearing loss (SSNHL) requiring intervention within 24 hours of onset (refer directly to the Meridian Audiology & Emergency Department Protocol).

3.1.5. Active, severe epistaxis unresponsive to initial first aid measures.

3.1.6. Suspected head and neck malignancy without prior imaging (CT/MRI) or biopsy (refer directly to Meridian Oncology Services).

3.1.7. Management of newly placed tracheostomies or acute tracheostomy emergencies.

3.1.8. Pediatric ENT cases for patients under 2 years of age (refer to Meridian Pediatric ENT Services at the Sterling Site).

4. Typical Appointment Durations

4.1. The following standard appointment durations are allocated to ensure thorough patient care and efficient clinic flow:

4.1.1. New Patient Consultation: 45 minutes.

4.1.2. Established Patient Follow-up: 20 minutes.

4.1.3. Minor In-clinic Procedure (e.g., cerumen removal, nasal endoscopy): 30 minutes.

5. Patient Preparation Instructions

5.1. Patients will receive the following preparation instructions based on their scheduled appointment type:

- 5.1.1. General: Bring a comprehensive list of all current medications, including over-the-counter supplements and dosages. Bring any relevant prior imaging reports (e.g., CT scans, MRIs) or audiograms if performed by external providers.
- 5.1.2. Allergy Testing: Discontinue all oral antihistamines (e.g., loratadine, cetirizine, diphenhydramine) for a minimum of 48 hours prior to the scheduled skin prick test.
- 5.1.3. Laryngoscopy (Flexible/Stroboscopy): Do not eat or drink anything for 4 hours prior to the procedure.
- 5.1.4. Hearing Evaluation: Patients experiencing excessive cerumen accumulation will be advised to use over-the-counter earwax softening drops (e.g., carbamide peroxide) for 3-5 days prior to their appointment.

6. Meridian Health Plan Coverage for ENT Procedures

6.1. The following table outlines the coverage for standard ENT procedures under Meridian Health Partners' four primary insurance plans:

Procedure Category	Meridian BasicCare	Meridian Advantage	Meridian Premier	Meridian Elite
Initial/Follow-up Consultations	Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Basic Diagnostic Scopes	Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Cerumen Removal	Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Tympanometry/Audiometry	Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Allergy Testing (Skin Prick)	Not Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Flexible Laryngoscopy	Not Covered	Covered	Covered	Covered
Allergy Testing (RAST)	Not Covered	Not Covered	Covered	Covered
Sinus CT Scan (MHP Ordered)	Not Covered	Not Covered	Covered	Covered
Stroboscopy	Not Covered	Not Covered	Covered	Covered
Expedited Scheduling	Not Included	Not Included	Not Included	Included

7. Referral Turnaround Commitment

7.1. The Department of Otolaryngology commits to the following turnaround times for received referrals:

7.1.1. Non-Urgent Referrals:

7.1.1.1. Acknowledgement of receipt to referring provider within 2 business days.

7.1.1.2. Patient scheduling for the initial appointment within 10 business days of referral receipt.

7.1.2. Urgent Referrals (e.g., sudden unilateral hearing loss after 24 hours, rapidly progressing voice changes):

7.1.2.1. Acknowledgement of receipt to referring provider within 1 business day.

7.1.2.2. Patient scheduling for the initial appointment within 3 business days of referral receipt.

7.2. All referrals are reviewed by Dr. Anya Sharma (Head of ENT Services) or Dr. Ben Carter (Senior Clinician) within 24 hours of receipt to determine urgency and appropriate scheduling.